

Interview Notes: Professor Sarah Cho

Date: October 9, 2026 **Place:** Room 1301, UTPB **Time:** [add the time]

Appearance and Behavior

- Very kind, smiling, polite, and helpful
- Warm and patient; checked if I understood words (“Do you know what template means?”)
- Laughed easily and made jokes (“You’re my favorite”)
- [Add: what she was wearing, how she sat or moved, her expressions]

My Observations as Interviewer

- I was nervous about my English accent
- I was surprised by how open and receptive she was
- Her story pulled me in
- She also writes in her second language, like me. That made me feel more comfortable
- [Add any other personal observation]

Questions and Answers (summary)

Q: How long have you worked in this profession? A: [Check your recording: the transcript says “60 years,” which is probably a transcription error]

Q: How did you decide to dedicate yourself to this field? A: Book editor in Korea for 10 years. Saw reading and writing as communication (sending and receiving messages). Went to grad school (four different schools) and became a communication teacher.

Q: What do you like most about your work? A: Meeting people.

Q: What is the most complex thing you have had to write? A: Research papers. Many sections (abstract, intro, method, analysis, discussion, conclusion, references). Each one reflects years of work, not just a summary.

Q: Did anyone teach you? A: Professors in grad school. It took her 10 years to learn.

Q: What advice would you have liked when you started? A: Clear templates to follow. Now she gives her students templates: fill in the blanks, start easier, it doesn’t have to be perfect.

Q: What is your writing process? A: Outline first with bullet points (intro 1-2-3, body 1-2-3). Main points first, details later. If the structure doesn’t work, she starts over without wasting much time.

Q: What do you do with writer’s block? A: New experiences: a new place, new restaurant, new food (maybe Cuban!). Needs “full-body processing,” not just reading.

Q: How do you get feedback? A: Paid AI version. Asks for comments and suggestions, NOT rewrites. Friends and husband are too busy.

Q: A piece of writing that is personal to you? A: Her papers are “like my children.” Most recent one took 10 years: Korean small-store owners with limited English building relationships with US customers. About to be published.

Q: One that didn’t turn out well? A: Paper based on interviews with North Koreans. Took 6 years, published in a weaker journal. Started too early in grad school, poor interview design.

Q: What did you learn from it? A: Preparing and designing interviews is as important as writing. Have everything ready before you start writing.

Q: How do you handle criticism? A: Presents at conferences (next: Atlanta, March 2027). Comments help; criticism hurts. Key: “Don’t take it personally.”

Q: Did your writing style change? A: Yes. Editor = audience-centered, easy to follow. Academic = author-centered, more intellectual, for a small group.

Q: What do you think about AI? A: Very useful for comments and suggestions.

Q: One piece of advice for students? A: Practice. Writing is like speaking. Reading is different from writing, and short texts (Instagram) are different from long writing.

Q: What resource do you recommend? A: Google Scholar: “standing on the shoulders of giants.”

Reflection After the Interview

- What impacted me most: she is a successful writer in her second language. Her best paper is about people with limited English, “like me,” she said.
- Idea that repeated most: good writing takes time, structure, and practice (10 years to learn, 10 years for one paper, templates, outlines).
- Possible throughline for the essay:
 - Option A: Good writing is built step by step, not born: structure first, then practice and feedback.
 - Option B: Writing in a second language is a long climb, but you don’t climb alone (professors, templates, feedback, “the shoulders of giants”).